“Count the seconds between contractions.”

Now, Léa needed to silence the hammering in her head because Rose was right—she’d never done this before. Léa’s pulse pounded, making it hard to concentrate. She closed her eyes and took a few quiet breaths, allowing her time to slow her pulse and clear her head. She’d seen Josef do that when situations came at him from all directions and he needed to ground himself. Opening her eyes, she felt better. Nadiya’s alarm was natural for a first-time mother. What she didn’t need was for Léa to panic, too. Though she wished Josef could be here, she was confident she would handle the labor, until he returned in the morning.

Focus! Towels, water, and something to wrap the baby in. She moved swiftly, collecting all she needed and putting water on the stove heat. Then she found the knife Josef had used to cut the umbilical cord and sterilized it by holding it over the flame on the stove.

She went to the back room, where Nadiya walked and leaned on Rose for support. She sang in Russian, filling the room with a beautiful, melancholy song. “Ohhhh,” Nadiya cried out. “Another one.”

“A minute between contractions,” Rose said.

Could she be ready so soon? Maybe she’d had the contractions for a while before coming to the sick bay. “Let’s settle her on the bed.”

“Get behind her back, so that she’s upright and will have more strength to push,” Léa told Rose.

Léa placed her hand on Nadiya’s swollen midsection, as she’d seen Josef do with Maria. She felt the baby low in the womb. Nadiya’s abdomen tightened sharply as another contraction seized her.

“I think you’re ready to push,” Léa instructed.

Nadiya gave a weak push.

“Try harder, with more force. Your baby wants to see the world,” Léa said.

Rose stroked Nadiya’s back and wiped the sweat from her forehead with a cloth.

Nadiya cried out, gripping Rose’s hand tightly. “I can’t,” she sobbed.

“Yes, you can,” Rose urged. “Do it for your baby. Sing to her the way you were singing just now.”

She hummed a slow melody, interspersed with cries of pain.

“That’s right, push Nadiya,” Rose said, encouraging her.